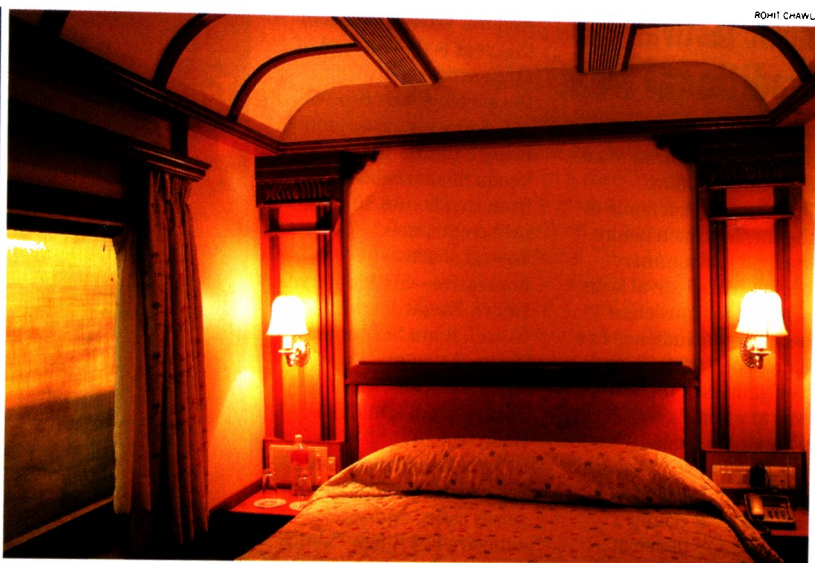




ROHIT CHAWLA

lopment Corporation and the Indian Railways, is a shorter journey restricted to Rajasthan and includes lesser known heritage sites while India on Wheels has the longest trip, a 17-day itinerary that combines the best of the Palace on Wheels and Deccan Odyssey. The Great Indian Royale Express has lesser stops but a more elaborate—and expensive—experience which also includes the Taj Mahal, while The Royal Orient combines sites in Gujarat and Rajasthan.

What has clearly appealed to a foreign audience is the majestic setting, high-class amenities and the convenience of travelling by night and stopping by day for group tours conducted by

DECCAN ODYSSEY

ITINERARY: Mumbai-Jaigadh-Ganapatipule-Ratangiri-Sindhudurg-Tarkarli-Sawantwadi-Goa-Kolhapur-Pune-Aurangabad-Ajanta-Nashik-Mumbai

TARIFF: Rs 1,33,610 per person for a seven-day journey

AMENITIES: 11 passenger cars with a conference car that converts into dance floor at night

trained guides and in premium modes of transport. The centrally air-conditioned coaches have bars, lounges, elaborate suites and bedrooms, running hot and cold water, satellite television, modern communication and chefs, who dish out regal fare. The interconnected passenger cars make the experience akin to a travelling five-star hotel. "Air travel is no competition for luxury trains. Sure, it is steep but it's not aimed at those looking for cheap fares. If you consider what's on offer, it's a steal," says Akash Malhotra, a tour operator from Mumbai whose clients are regularly routed to luxury trains. "In a luxury train, you are treated like a king, your every need is catered to, it's like living and travelling in a five-star palace and the guests realise it," he adds.

That probably explains why both Palace on Wheels and the Deccan Odyssey have received glowing tributes

from a majority of their customers. "The tour guides were excellent. The cabin assistants deserve special mention for absolutely fantastic service, pleasant nature and nothing-is-ever-a-problem attitude that helped make this train journey the most enjoyable holiday I ever had," says Leo Kirjakidis and family from Australia of the Deccan Odyssey. Richard Kruger and his wife from the US were equally smitten: "What a wonderful introduction to India. We will recommend this to everyone." Chetna Jivan from the Seychelles, says about the Palace: "Was it real or a dream? Seven days of utter bliss. The trip was fantastically organised."

The Golden Chariot is built to accommodate more than a hundred passengers and will flag off sometime in March. If initial reports are to be believed, the train has already been booked in advance. "We have started the process of marketing the train at all major destinations in the world," says Sanjay Chhabra, chairman and managing director of Mapple Group which is in charge of marketing, hospitality and services.

With a valet to cater to your every whim and fancy in the lap of opulence and luxury as you travel through some of the most breathtakingly scenic landscapes in the world, it's not surprising why one would choose the railways tracks over rushed check-in counters at any of the country's airports. ■



HR RAJASHEKAR